

Michigan, Virginia are key 2028 Democratic contests

送信者: EG United States 受信日時: 2026-08-20 01:24

【メール原文】

The Democrats' 2028 primary calendar shakeup will define the path to victory. In a major change from previous competitive cycles, the Democratic National Committee has put South Carolina first, followed by Nevada, New Hampshire, and New Mexico. Michigan and Virginia round out the pre-Super Tuesday slate, with Iowa pushed back. New Mexico, Michigan, and Virginia are newcomers to the pre-Super Tuesday calendar; campaigns there will have no obvious historical analogues.

United States

[Customize Email Preferences](#)

Michigan and Virginia will be defining races of 2028 Democratic primary

19 Aug 2026 12:22 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

*

The Democratic Party's reshuffled 2028 primary calendar, anchored by South Carolina at the start and Michigan and Virginia just before Super Tuesday, creates a voting sequence with no clear historical precedent.

*

South Carolina will play an important role in winnowing the field, as candidates will need either strong appeal among Black voters or a clear shot at later-primary states to advance past the opening contest.

*

Michigan and Virginia are likely to be decisive—a sweep by one candidate will very likely secure the nomination, while a split could set up a final contest between the two leading candidates on Super Tuesday.

The Democrats' 2028 primary calendar shakeup will define the path to victory. In a major change from previous competitive cycles, the Democratic National Committee has put South Carolina first, followed by Nevada, New Hampshire, and New Mexico. Michigan and Virginia round out the pre-Super Tuesday slate, with Iowa pushed back. New Mexico, Michigan, and Virginia are newcomers to the pre-Super Tuesday calendar; campaigns there will have no obvious historical analogues.

Of these states, Michigan and Virginia will carry the most weight; they are likely to determine whether the nomination is settled early or goes to a final contest between two leading candidates on Super Tuesday. Given the array of potential Democratic contenders in 2028, understanding the dynamics of early-primary states will be essential to reading the race.

South Carolina will test Black-voter appeal and narrow the field without deciding it. Keeping South Carolina in the opening slot for the second cycle running—rather than handing the slot to Nevada, which was also under consideration—was explicitly an attempt to elevate Southern Black voters in presidential selection. South Carolina's Democratic electorate is more than 50% Black, the largest of the early-primary states; it is impossible to win there without winning a major portion of the Black vote.

Placement in the calendar matters, however. The opening two or three primaries play an important role in narrowing the field, demonstrating to donors, party elites, and voters which candidates have a real shot at the nomination. But they are rarely decisive: They do not typically lead to the field consolidating around a single figure, and their winners—in 2020, Pete Buttigieg in Iowa and Senator Bernie Sanders (I-VT) in New Hampshire—are just as often not the eventual nominees.

That means strong appeal to Black voters is likely to be sufficient to pass the first electoral hurdle but not necessary. Candidates who perform well in South Carolina will be able to stay in the race through Michigan. But candidates who don't perform well will likely also be able to stay in, under two conditions: If they have clearly communicated low expectations for South Carolina, and if they are polling well in other early-primary states. This will be the likely strategy for candidates like Buttigieg, who polls poorly among Black voters but would have a plausible shot at New Hampshire or Michigan.

Nevada and New Mexico will be important tests of Hispanic support. Hispanic Democrats like Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-NY) and Senator Ruben Gallego (D-AZ), on opposite sides of the party's ideological divide, will see both states' large Hispanic populations as potential opportunities. But these are likely to be relatively open contests focused on local appeals and turnout drives.

Hispanic Democrats do not cleanly fall on one end of the progressive-moderate spectrum, though the Democratic electorate in New Mexico has a somewhat more progressive lean than in Nevada. Garnering the support of the influential Culinary Workers Union (which has opposed some progressive policies such as Medicare for All) would be a major boost to any candidate in Nevada.

Michigan and Virginia are most likely to be the decisive races. After the first four primaries begin to winnow the field, the Michigan and Virginia contests—in large, demographically diverse states that better reflect the wider Democratic coalition—will determine who has momentum going into Super Tuesday. A candidate who sweeps both is very likely to be the nominee; if the states split, Super Tuesday will likely be contested between the winners.

If the 2028 primary plays out as the 2020 primary did, with a large moderate/center-left field against a thin progressive field, these two primaries will play a crucial role in consolidating moderates before Super Tuesday.

Michigan's position could benefit progressives, while Virginia offers opportunity for centrist candidates. Abdul El-Sayed's victory earlier this month demonstrates that progressives can win a Michigan primary, especially against a weak or fractured moderate field. Progressive figures like Sanders—who won there in 2016—retain real influence in the state, reinforced by the importance of the United Auto Workers. Moreover, over 40% of Michigan's Democratic voters are non-college whites, who are more drawn to economic populism than cultural progressivism.

Virginia is probably more fruitful ground for center-left or moderate Democrats, such as Governor Wes Moore of neighboring Maryland. Its demographic profile is relatively evenly spread across college and non-college whites and Black voters. This will be a final chance for candidates who did well in South Carolina but nowhere else, and for the remaining moderates.

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States
daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net
Clayton Allen
Practice Head, United States
+1 202.903.0027
allen@eurasiagroup.net
EG United States
unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.

X-HG-DocID cmt07hmk5c03k07lw3l5of8qi

[Opt Out](#) | [Customize Email Preferences](#)